

D375

Marketing Communications and Storytelling

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

The marketing lead at a regional coffee roaster, which has sponsored the city marathon for six years, drafts four objectives for a spring campaign. The agency's creative director prefers bold colors. Which objective is written in SMART form?

- A. Sponsor the marathon again with a larger banner.
- B. Post on every social platform daily to raise awareness.
- C. Grow online bean subscriptions from 2,000 to 2,600 by June 30.
- D. Become the most loved coffee brand in the region.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An objective reads: "Increase newsletter sign-ups by 15%." Which SMART element is missing?

- A. Time-bound
- B. Relevant
- C. Measurable
- D. Nothing; any objective with a percentage is SMART.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A furniture retailer runs TV spots saying its tables are "built to last a lifetime" and in-store signs about solid-wood durability. Its Instagram ads say "cheap and trendy—replace it every season." The TV budget rose 20% this year. What is the main integrated-communications problem?

- A. The Instagram message contradicts the brand's core promise; all channels should carry one consistent message.
- B. Instagram should never be used for furniture brands.
- C. Each channel should have its own core message to fit its audience, so nothing is wrong.
- D. The TV budget is too large compared with social.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A credit union with 40 branches and a new logo asks its agency for a two-minute brand video. The agency has won three regional awards. Which story structure best follows storytelling principles?

- A. A list of loan rates and account features over upbeat music.
- B. A showcase of the new logo in the agency's award-winning style.
- C. The CEO describes the credit union's 70-year history and its growth to 40 branches.
- D. A young couple struggles to afford a first home; a credit union advisor helps them build a plan; they get the keys.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A sneaker startup posts a launch video on its own YouTube channel, pays a sports website for banner ads, and gets a free review in a running magazine after the editor tried the shoe. The launch video got 80,000 views in its first week. Which of these is earned media?

- A. All three, since each reached new people.
- B. The running magazine's review.
- C. The launch video, because 80,000 viewers chose to watch it.
- D. The banner ads on the sports website.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which of the following is an example of owned media?

- A. A promoted (boosted) post on the company's own social page.
- B. A customer's unprompted five-star review.
- C. The company's email newsletter sent to its own subscribers.
- D. A sponsored post on an influencer's feed.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A new plant-based snack brand, founded by two former chefs, launches a campaign whose objective is to build awareness among 18- to 34-year-olds in three cities. Its packaging is fully recyclable. Which metric best shows whether the campaign met its objective?

- A. Customer lifetime value.
- B. Aided brand recall and reach among 18- to 34-year-olds in the three cities.
- C. Share of packaging that is recyclable.
- D. Online sales conversion rate.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A regional TV buy reaches 40% of target households with an average frequency of 3. The station's evening anchor recently won a local Emmy. The buy costs \$60,000. How many gross rating points does it deliver?

- A. 43
- B. 120
- C. 40
- D. 1,500

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A media plan calls for 300 GRPs, and the buy is expected to reach 60% of the target audience. What average frequency is needed?

- A. 18,000
- B. 0.2
- C. 60
- D. 5

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A B2B software firm with offices in four states wants more qualified leads for its scheduling tool. Its sales VP, who joined last spring, suggests buying a contact list. Which tactic is an inbound approach?

- A.** Stop all paid advertising, since inbound never uses paid media.
- B.** Open a fifth state office to be closer to buyers.
- C.** Publish a free scheduling-templates guide that ranks for what buyers search, with a sign-up form to download it.
- D.** Cold-email a purchased list of 20,000 office managers.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In the inbound flywheel, a company sends new customers onboarding tips and invites them to a user community where they recommend the product to others. Which stage is this?

- A.** Delight
- B.** Attract
- C.** None; post-sale work belongs only to customer service, not marketing.
- D.** Engage

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A retirement-planning firm wants to reach adults aged 55 to 64 who research money decisions carefully and read long articles before acting. The firm's summer intern is very active on a short-video app. Which message and channel choice fits best?

- A.** A text-message blast with a limited-time discount code.
- B.** Fifteen-second trend videos on the short-video app.
- C.** Run the same content on every channel equally so no one is missed.
- D.** An email series and in-depth articles or webinars on turning savings into retirement income.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

The marketing lead at a regional coffee roaster, ~~which has sponsored the city marathon for six years~~, drafts four objectives for a spring campaign. ~~The agency's creative director prefers bold colors~~. Which objective is written in SMART form?

Target word: which objective is SMART **Decides:** Only one option has a measure, a baseline, and a deadline tied to the business.

A	Camouflage	Answers the sponsorship detail; it is an activity with no measured result.
B	Adjacent category	That is a tactic, not an objective, and it has no measurable outcome.
C	Correct	Specific, measurable (2,000 to 2,600), realistic, relevant to revenue, and time-bound (June 30).
D	Dropped element	No measure and no deadline; it is a wish, not an objective.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

An objective reads: "Increase newsletter sign-ups by 15%." Which SMART element is missing?

Target word: find the missing element **Decides:** There is a measure (15%) but no deadline.

A	Correct	No date or period is given, so progress cannot be judged on schedule.
B	Adjacent category	Nothing in the statement shows it conflicts with business goals; the clear gap is timing.
C	Confusion set	The 15% target already makes it measurable.
D	Absolute language	A number alone covers only one of five elements.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A furniture retailer runs TV spots saying its tables are "built to last a lifetime" and in-store signs about solid-wood durability. Its Instagram ads say "cheap and trendy—replace it every season." ~~The TV budget rose 20% this year~~. What is the main integrated-communications problem?

Target word: the IMC flaw **Decides:** One channel contradicts the core brand message.

A	Correct	IMC requires a single core message across channels, adapted only in format.
B	Absolute language	Channel choice is not the problem; the conflicting message is.
C	Inverted operation	Reverses the IMC principle; format adapts, the core message does not.
D	Camouflage	Budget size does not decide message consistency.

4. Answer D Concept 3

A credit union ~~with 40 branches and a new logo~~ asks its agency for a two-minute brand video. ~~The agency has won three regional awards~~. Which story structure best follows storytelling principles?

Target word: best story structure **Decides:** Customer is the hero with a conflict; the brand is the guide.

A	Dropped element	No character, no conflict, no resolution; it is an ad, not a story.
B	Camouflage	Answers the logo and awards details, which do not make a story.
C	Adjacent category	Makes the brand the hero; the audience has no one to identify with.
D	Correct	Customer-hero, clear conflict, brand as guide, and a resolution the audience can feel.

5. Answer B Concept 4

A sneaker startup posts a launch video on its own YouTube channel, pays a sports website for banner ads, and gets a free review in a running magazine after the editor tried the shoe. ~~The launch video got 80,000 views in its first week.~~ Which of these is earned media?

Target word: identify earned media **Decides:** The magazine review was given freely by a third party.

A	Absolute language	Reach does not define the category; control and payment do.
B	Correct	Coverage a third party gives without payment is earned.
C	Camouflage	View count does not change the category; the company's own channel is owned media.
D	Confusion set	Bought space is paid media.

6. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

Which of the following is an example of owned media?

Target word: reverse: from category to example **Decides:** Owned = a channel the company controls without paying for placement.

A	Adjacent category	Paying to extend reach makes it paid media even on an owned page.
B	Confusion set	Freely given by a third party, so it is earned.
C	Correct	The company controls the list and the channel.
D	Confusion set	Paid placement on someone else's channel is paid media.

7. Answer B Concept 5

A new plant-based snack brand, ~~founded by two former chefs,~~ launches a campaign whose objective is to build awareness among 18- to 34-year-olds in three cities. ~~Its packaging is fully recyclable.~~ Which metric best shows whether the campaign met its objective?

Target word: metric for an awareness objective **Decides:** The objective is awareness, a top-of-funnel stage.

A	Confusion set	A retention and profitability measure, not awareness.
B	Correct	Awareness is measured by reach and recall in the target audience.
C	Camouflage	A product fact, not a campaign result.
D	Adjacent category	A conversion metric belongs to a later funnel stage.

8. Answer B Concept 6

A regional TV buy reaches 40% of target households with an average frequency of 3. ~~The station's evening anchor recently won a local Emmy.~~ The buy costs \$60,000. How many gross rating points does it deliver?

Target word: GRPs **Decides:** $\text{GRP} = \text{reach} \times \text{frequency} = 40 \times 3$.

A	Inverted operation	Adds reach and frequency instead of multiplying.
B	Correct	$40 \text{ reach points} \times 3 \text{ average frequency} = 120 \text{ GRPs}$.
C	Dropped element	Reach alone; ignores frequency.
D	Adjacent category	$\$60,000 / 40$ is a cost per reach point, not GRPs.

9. Answer D Concept 6 · transfer

A media plan calls for 300 GRPs, and the buy is expected to reach 60% of the target audience. What average frequency is needed?

Target word: solve for frequency **Decides:** Frequency = GRPs / reach = 300 / 60.

A	Inverted operation	Multiplies GRPs by reach instead of dividing.
B	Inverted operation	Divides reach by GRPs, the wrong way round.
C	Wrong stem number	The reach figure, not frequency.
D	Correct	300 / 60 = 5 exposures on average.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A B2B software firm ~~with offices in four states~~ wants more qualified leads for its scheduling tool. Its sales VP, ~~who joined last spring~~, suggests buying a contact list. Which tactic is an inbound approach?

Target word: which tactic is inbound **Decides:** Inbound draws buyers with content they seek out.

A	Absolute language	Inbound can use paid promotion of helpful content; “never” is false.
B	Camouflage	Office count does not decide inbound vs. outbound.
C	Correct	Buyer-initiated, value-first content that attracts and converts leads.
D	Confusion set	Interruption outreach to people who did not ask is outbound.

11. Answer A Concept 7 · transfer

In the inbound flywheel, a company sends new customers onboarding tips and invites them to a user community where they recommend the product to others. Which stage is this?

Target word: reverse: from activity to stage **Decides:** Post-purchase delight turns customers into promoters.

A	Correct	Helping existing customers succeed so they promote the brand is the delight stage.
B	Confusion set	Attract draws in strangers with content, before they are customers.
C	Absolute language	The flywheel explicitly includes delighting customers.
D	Adjacent category	Engage builds relationships with prospects and closes the sale; these are already customers.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A retirement-planning firm wants to reach adults aged 55 to 64 who research money decisions carefully and read long articles before acting. ~~The firm’s summer intern is very active on a short video app.~~ Which message and channel choice fits best?

Target word: fit message and channel to audience **Decides:** A careful, research-driven audience that reads long-form content.

A	Adjacent category	A quick conversion tactic that does not fit a slow, researched decision.
B	Camouflage	Follows the intern’s habits, not the audience’s.
C	Absolute language	Ignores the audience insight; spreads budget where the audience is not.
D	Correct	Matches the audience’s habits and considered decision style.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	SMART objectives	A campaign objective must be specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound before any strategy or creative work begins.	Treating a vague wish like “build awareness” as an objective.	A goal statement with no number, no baseline, or no deadline.
2	Integrated message consistency	In integrated marketing communications every channel carries the same core message and brand promise, adapted only in format.	Giving each channel its own separate core message.	Several channels in one stem with taglines that pull in different directions.
3	Customer as hero of the story	Brand stories connect when the customer is the hero with a problem, and the brand is the guide that helps them win.	Making the company, its history, or its product the hero.	“Which story structure” or “who is the main character?”
4	Paid, owned, and earned media	Paid = you buy the space; owned = channels you control; earned = coverage or sharing others give you freely.	Calling your own social posts earned, or a boosted post owned.	Who controls the channel and whether money changed hands.
5	Match metric to funnel objective	An awareness campaign is judged by reach and recall; a conversion campaign by actions such as sales or sign-ups.	Judging an awareness campaign by sales conversion rate.	The stated campaign objective names a funnel stage.
6	Reach, frequency, and GRPs	Gross rating points = reach (% of target) × average frequency.	Adding reach and frequency, or dropping frequency.	A reach percentage and an average frequency in the same stem.
7	Inbound methodology	Inbound attracts people with helpful content they seek out, then engages and delights them so customers fuel growth (the flywheel).	Calling interruption tactics like cold lists or TV spots inbound.	Who starts the contact: the buyer searching, or the marketer interrupting.
8	Audience drives message and channel	Define the target audience and its insight first; message and channel choices follow from where and how that audience engages.	Picking a channel because it is popular or the team likes it.	Audience traits (age, habits, decision style) followed by a channel choice.

Course scope (public description): Marketing Communications and Storytelling introduces learners to the principles of integrative marketing communications with an emphasis on storytelling and creativity. Storytelling skills enable marketers to build relationships by making connections with their intended audience. Digital storytelling integrates the use of technology to create a cohesive narrative across various platforms that evokes emotions and feelings about a brand. These efforts can lead to customer acquisition or conversion outcomes. In this course, the creative storytelling process begins with a clear SMART objective that drives strategy development, the creative direction, and the execution of an integrative marketing communication campaign. Campaign types, media channels, messages, timelines, and market development considerations are taught within the context of both digital and traditional application. Learners will also have the opportunity to complete the HubSpot Inbound Marketing certification to learn industry best practices and to enhance marketability within the marketing profession.